Conyo English

Ariane Macalinga Borlongan[1,*] **Jasper Kyle Catapang**[2]
Kevin Samejon[3] **Sae Asamura**[4]

[1] *Institute of Global Studies and The Migration Linguistics Initiative, Tokyo University of Foreign Studies, 3-11-1 Asahi-cho, Fuchu, Tokyo 183-8534, Japan*
[2] *Graduate School of Global Studies, Tokyo University of Foreign Studies, 3-11-1 Asahi-cho, Fuchu, Tokyo 183-8534, Japan*
[3] *Department of English, University of Nebraska at Omaha, 192 Arts and Sciences Hall, 6001 Dodge Street, Omaha, NE 68182-0175, USA*
[4] *School of Language and Culture Studies, Tokyo University of Foreign Studies, 3-11-1 Asahi-cho, Fuchu, Tokyo 183-8534, Japan*
[*] *Corresponding author*

This article provides a linguistic description of Conyo English, a sociolect of Philippine English marked by English–Tagalog code-switching and associated with private university-educated youth in Metro Manila. Building on Perez (1993) and Borlongan (2015), it analyzes 12.8 hours of unscripted peer-group conversation recorded by 45 undergraduates in 15 groups from four Metro Manila universities between September 2023 and January 2024. Phonologically, Conyo English shares the segmental features of Philippine English, follows Tagalog-like stress and syllable timing (with Cebuano-influenced vowels and intonation among Cebuano-background speakers), and displays a recurring intonation pattern we call the conyo contour. Lexically and grammatically, it is built on an English clause frame into which Tagalog discourse particles (*na*, *pa*, *naman*, *diba*), Tagalog verbal morphology on English stems (*na-touch*, *mag-go*), and light-verb constructions such as *make* + Tagalog root (*make sabi*) are systematically inserted. Speakers with a Cebuano background draw on Cebuano particles and syntax in parallel ways. We model variation within it as a gradient of conyoness along three dimensions, particle density, hybridization depth, and social indexical load, and argue that Conyo English is an enregistered sociolect whose emergence shows Philippine English moving from endonormative stabilization toward differentiation.

Date: November 14, 2026
Correspondence: ariane@tufs.ac.jp
ORCID: Borlongan 0000-0003-2734-2265
Catapang 0000-0002-4510-0975
Samejon 0000-0002-9207-5872
Website: https://www.tufs.ac.jp/english/research/

東京外国語大学
Tokyo University of Foreign Studies

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1 Introduction

The global spread of English has produced distinct, localized varieties across Asia, Africa, and Latin America, and most of the world's English users are now non-native speakers who use the language in education, governance, commerce, and personal life (Crystal, 2003). The World Englishes paradigm recognizes these nativized varieties as legitimate systems shaped by local languages, ideologies, and histories (Kachru, 1985; Bolton, 2006). The Philippines is a prototypical Outer Circle country in Kachru's (1985) model: English, entrenched through American colonial education in the early twentieth century, is institutionalized in education, media, government, and commerce.

Where Philippine English (PhE) stands in its development remains debated. Schneider (2007) placed it at the nativization phase of his Dynamic Model, short of endonormative stabilization. Borlongan (2016) argues that it has since reached that fourth phase, pointing to an "Event X" (the rejection of U.S. military bases in the early 1990s) and to growing codification through corpora, dictionaries, and published descriptions. Martin (2014), by contrast, stresses that English remains unevenly distributed

in Filipino society and proposes inner, outer, and expanding circles of use within the Philippines itself. This internal stratification underlies Gonzales's (2017) notion of Philippine Englishes: substrate-influenced varieties such as Ilokano English and Chavacano English, occupational sociolects such as Yaya English (Bautista, 1982) and Call Center English (Tinio, 2013), and hybrid registers such as Taglish, Hokaglish, and Conyo English. Documenting this variation is, as Lee and Borlongan (2023) argue, itself a reflection of the national variety's maturity.

Conyo English is among the most socially charged of these varieties. It is associated with youth, private schooling, and the upper-middle class, and with a recognizable pattern of English–Tagalog code-switching. Perez (1993) recorded code-switching among students of a private women's college, and Bautista (1996) described a related 'Colegiala English'. Borlongan (2015) introduced the label 'Conyo English' for a sociolect marked by frequent, less fluid alternation used in casual and playful talk, noting the *make* + Tagalog verb construction (*make kain* 'eat', *make tulog* 'sleep'), reduplication, and Tagalog particles such as *naman*, *na*, and *pa* inside English utterances. This article adopts the spelling *conyo* rather than *coño* to distinguish its contemporary Philippine sociolinguistic usage from the original Spanish term, which carries a vulgar connotation. Reyes (2017a, 2017b, 2020) situates the conyo speaker within discourses of colonial heritage, mestizo identity, and class performance, showing that the variety is mocked as inauthentic even as it signals urban sophistication. In her account, intonation, body language, and even dress become part of a semiotic system of cosmopolitan privilege, so that Conyo English is a social practice as much as a linguistic code: a way of claiming belonging, building peer relationships, or setting oneself apart.

Other work has examined conyo talk in online forums (Garvida, 2012), in Davao City, where it incorporates Cebuano alongside Tagalog and English (Albino et al., 2016), and in stylized TikTok performances (Laxa, 2020). Apart from Perez's (1993) covert recordings, however, nearly all of this evidence is mediated, elicited, or performed. No study has systematically described Conyo English as it is used in spontaneous peer interaction, where it does most of its social work. This matters because a variety defined by its social meaning is shaped in real-time interaction: particles that soften a request, switches that frame a disagreement, and prosody that signals irony are visible only in talk among peers, not in scripted performance or in speakers' reports about themselves.

This article addresses that gap with a description based on unscripted conversations among university students. Following the sociolectal descriptions of Yaya English (Bautista, 1982) and Filipino Domestic Worker English (Borlongan, 2022), we treat Conyo English not as deviant English or degraded Taglish but as a register shaped by youth culture, peer norms, and bilingual creativity. After the methods (Section 2), we describe its phonology (Section 3), lexicon (Section 4), and grammar (Section 5). The synthesis and discussion (Section 6) then turns to the social meanings of the variety, models variation within it as a gradient, offers a working definition that distinguishes Conyo English from Taglish more broadly, interprets Conyo English as an enregistered sociolect, and considers what it reveals about the current developmental stage of Philippine English.

2 Aims and methods

The study reported in this article has three aims: (1) to describe the phonological, lexical, and grammatical features of Conyo English in informal, unscripted peer interaction; (2) to compare these features with earlier accounts, especially Perez (1993), Borlongan (2015), and Reyes (2017a); and (3) to clarify how internal varieties of Philippine English develop and function among university-educated youth. Its premise is that Conyo English is best understood through everyday peer talk rather than through web forums (Garvida, 2012), social media (Laxa, 2020), or survey responses (Borlongan, 2015), all of which invite self-conscious performance.

2.1 Data collection

Fifteen peer groups (N = 45 undergraduates; ages 18–24; 26 men, 19 women) were recruited through purposive convenience sampling via peer networks at Ateneo de Manila University (n = 20), De La Salle University (n = 14), the University of Santo Tomas (n = 6), and the University of Asia and the Pacific (n = 5). Inclusion criteria were current enrollment and habitual English–Tagalog code-switching; students with formal linguistics training were excluded. All informants were bilingual in English and Tagalog, and some also had Cebuano (Bisaya) or Hiligaynon backgrounds. Two of these

Table 1: Methodological comparison between Perez (1993) and the present study

Category	Perez (1993)	Present study
Consent	Covert recording	Written informed consent
Setting	Private women's college; intimate talk	Four universities; casual group interaction
Recording technology	Cassette tape	Smartphones and digital voice recorders
Size of data	Not reported	12.8 hours, 15 groups, 45 speakers
Transcription	Manual	Automatic (Whisper) with full manual correction
Focus	Code-switching	Phonology, lexicon, grammar, social meaning

informants are originally from Metro Cebu and have a Cebuano language background; their speech is discussed separately where it diverges from that of the Tagalog-background majority.

Between September 2023 and January 2024, informants recorded unscripted conversations on smartphones or digital voice recorders in informal campus settings such as dorm lounges, cafeterias, hallways, and classrooms during group work, as well as on walks around campus. Groups ranged from 2 to 10 speakers (mostly 2–5), and sessions lasted 16 to 70 minutes (most about an hour), for a total of 12.8 hours. To avoid performance effects, the term 'Conyo English' was not mentioned in the instructions. Post-recording interviews with informants explored their perceptions of their own language use; these inform Section 6.

2.2 Transcription and analysis

Recordings were first transcribed automatically with OpenAI's Whisper multilingual speech recognition model. All transcripts were then corrected manually, with each recording reviewed several times over headphones to fill inaudible stretches, transcribe code-switched segments accurately, and annotate intonation, stress, paralinguistic cues, discourse particles, enclitics, reduplication, and morphosyntactic structures of interest. Manual correction was essential given the density of code-switching and overlapping speech. Phonological observations are based on auditory analysis, supplemented by pitch and intensity tracks for illustrative utterances (Figs. 1 and 2). Frequency counts were drawn from the corrected transcripts.

The analysis covers phonology, lexicon, grammar, and social meaning, the four areas used for Filipino Domestic Worker English (Borlongan, 2022), an approach that allows comparison with other Philippine sociolects. Perez's (1993) recordings serve as the main reference point for assessing continuity and change; Table 1 summarizes the methodological differences between the two studies.

3 Phonology

Earlier work on Conyo English has concentrated on code-switching and morphosyntax, mentioning its sound patterns only in passing (Perez, 1993; Borlongan, 2015). This section offers a systematic phonological account of the variety, covering segmental features and then stress, rhythm, and intonation.

3.1 Segmental features

Pronunciation varied across speakers, but several tendencies recurred. The voiced dental fricative /ð/ was regularly realized as [d], so that *there*, *that*, and *then* surfaced as [dɛɪ], [dat], and [den], as in (1) and (2). This substitution, a long-recognized hallmark of Philippine English (Llamzon, 1997; Borlongan, 2023b; Shahruddin et al., 2023), occurred even among speakers with strong English competence, which suggests that it is a norm rather than a performance error.

(1) That's [d]at's why they left *na*.

(2) Oh my god, there [d]ere was traffic *talaga kanina*.

Other features align with American English (AmE). Intervocalic /t/ in words such as *better* and *pretty* was often tapped, as in (3) and (4), though stress shifts for emphasis could block the tap. At the same

time, initial voiceless plosives were rarely aspirated, even in stressed monosyllables such as *pass*, *time*, and *kid*. The rhotic was typically the approximant [ɹ], even in Tagalog words such as *grabe* (an intensifier) and *parang* 'like', where a tap or trill would be expected, and *wh*-question words began with voiced [w] rather than [ʍ].

(3) That's so much be[ɾ]er *na*.

(4) She was like, pre[ɾ]y okay *naman*.

Vowels, by contrast, followed local norms. Unstressed syllables in words such as *people*, *logistical*, and *technical* had full vowels rather than schwa, and the lateral /l/ was rarely velarized. Yet in Tagalog words within English frames, speakers often avoided the peripheral vowels of Tagalog: *sipsip* 'sycophant' was produced with [ɪ] rather than [i] (5), and *maasim* 'sour' and *Undas* 'All Saints' Day' showed similar centralization (6, 7). This may be a phrase-final effect, but it may also be a social marker of conyo speech. Complex clusters were simplified or repaired by epenthesis, as in *three* [te.ˈɹi].

(5) But you then have to really make s[ɪ]ps[ɪ]p.

(6) It's so maas[e]m.

(7) How did you spend [ʊ]ndas?

The two Cebuano-background speakers shared the approximant [ɹ] but differed in other respects. They produced [θ], a sound absent from Cebuano, for English /ð/; they monophthongized final diphthongs (as in *condos*); and they kept peripheral vowels when switching into Cebuano. Taken together, these patterns contradict the common assumption that more educated Filipinos simply approximate AmE (Llamzon, 1969; Tayao, 2008). Conyo speakers combine selected AmE features, such as the tap, with local vowel and consonant norms.

3.2 Stress, rhythm, and intonation

Stress tends to follow Tagalog patterns, especially a preference for penultimate stress: *everyone* and *professional* were produced as [ɛv.ˈɹi.wʊn] and [pro.fɛ.ˈʃʌ.nɑl], and *hilarious* was resyllabified as [hɪ.ˈlɛɹ.jʌs]. Rhythm is syllable-timed: syllables are of roughly equal duration whether stressed or not, and they are repaired toward Tagalog CV(C) structure. These findings match descriptions of PhE as having variable stress placement and syllable-timed rhythm (Regala-Flores, 2014; Lee & Borlongan, 2023). Speakers who had studied abroad or described themselves as "third-culture kids" occasionally showed AmE-like stress, a sign of variation even within peer groups.

Intonation, too, aligns more closely with Tagalog than with AmE or British English. Most speakers used falling or plateau contours at phrase boundaries, following Tagalog tendencies (Richards, 2017), even in English clauses and even in questions (Fig. 1). Rising contours appeared mainly on tags such as *diba* and *right*, on phrase-final clitics such as *na* and *no*, and in emphatic utterances. Perez (1993) noted a "Tagalog intonation" in her students' English without characterizing its shape; our data confirm her observation and specify it as predominantly falling.

Against this Tagalog baseline, certain interjections and stock phrases such as *yeah bro*, *oh my god*, and *damn* [deɪːm] carried AmE-like contours and segmental lengthening, likely borrowed from global youth media. Conyo intonation therefore combines a Filipino base with pockets of AmE stylization, deployed according to stance and interactional purpose.

One pattern recurred often enough to warrant a name: the conyo contour (Fig. 2). It consists of an initial pitch rise at the left edge of a relatively short intonational phrase, a drop to a plateau that persists almost to the phrase boundary, and then a damped rise–fall within the final word. This right-edge shape may be a remnant of the Tagalog intonational phrase described by Kaufman (2005). Notably, the contour also occurred in the speech of a Cebuano-background speaker (Fig. 2B), which suggests that it belongs to Conyo English itself rather than resulting from simple transfer from Tagalog. Otherwise, Cebuano-background speakers used phrase-final rises more often, possibly under substrate influence and possibly reflecting the animated topics of their conversations.



Figure 1: Pitch (blue line) and intensity (red line) contours of the question *Why won't they just assign one to you that lets you do whatever you want?* Pitch falls rather than rises at the phrase-final boundaries. Intensity drops only at the right edge of the first phrase and remains steady on the second, despite the fall in pitch.

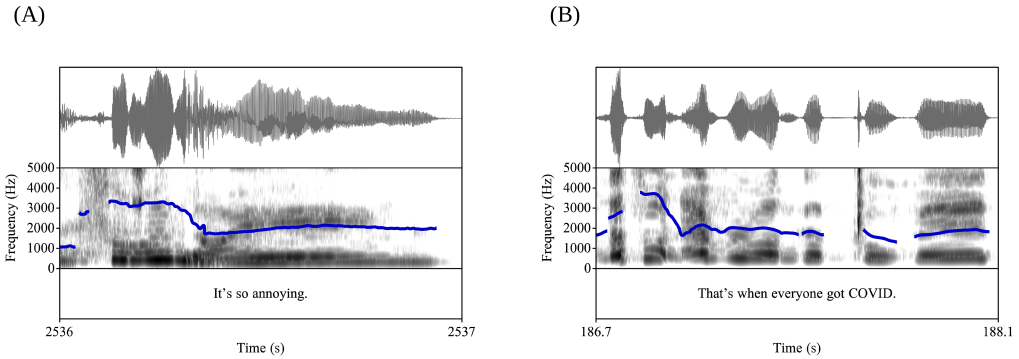


Figure 2: The conyo contour. The blue line indicates pitch. (A) A Tagalog-background speaker's production of *It's so annoying.* (B) A Cebuano-background speaker's production of *That's when everyone got COVID.*

4 Lexicon

This section examines the lexicon of Conyo English in two parts: the discourse particles and markers that give the variety its pragmatic texture, and the lexical innovations that make up its social vocabulary, classified by the word-formation processes Bautista (1997) identified for Philippine English. Hybrid verb forms, which carry grammatical as well as lexical meaning, are treated under grammar (Section 5).

4.1 Discourse particles and markers

Tagalog discourse particles form the pragmatic core of Conyo English. They are inserted untranslated into English clauses, where they do work that English would assign to whole clauses or modal constructions: managing agreement, cause, sequence, tentativeness, and aspect (Table 2).

The particles cluster at clause edges, where they act as both rhythm markers and stance operators, and they frequently combine (*kasi* … *eh*, *parang* … *naman*), packing several pragmatic meanings into a single prosodic unit. This layering carries Tagalog prosody into English clauses and produces the familiar cadence of conyo speech.

English discourse markers such as *like*, *so*, *yeah*, *oh*, *okay*, *right*, *actually*, and *you know* come from a global youth register, where they carry their usual functions. *Like* opens turns and softens directives, *yeah* and *okay* acknowledge and hand over the floor, *oh* introduces evaluation (*Oh my gosh, that's*

Table 2: Tagalog discourse particles in Conyo English

Particle	Function in Conyo English	Example
diba	Seeks agreement or shared understanding (‘right?’)	Like, *diba* super busy *sila*?
kasi	Gives a reason or justification (‘because’)	*Kasi*, we have class tomorrow, *eh*.
tapos	Introduces sequence (‘then, after that’)	*Tapos*, he was telling the American guy.
parang	Marks tentativeness or approximation (‘like, it seems’)	*Parang* okay *lang naman*.
kaya	Signals inference or result (‘so, that’s why’)	. . . *kaya* we should prepare.
eh	Softens stance; marks mild contrast	Auntie took care of me when I was little, *eh*.
naman	Adds politeness, down-toning, or empathy	*Parang* okay *lang naman*.
na / *pa*	Completion vs. continuation (‘already’ / ‘still’)	Go *na*! / Wait *pa*!

a lot), and *right* and *actually* soften corrections or qualify a claim. In Conyo English, however, they are paired with Tagalog functional equivalents: *like* with *parang*, *so* with *kaya* or *tapos*, *right* with *diba*. The two sets alternate and combine (*like, diba*; *so, tapos*), giving speakers two parallel systems for hedging, sequencing, and seeking agreement. Choosing between them lets a speaker signal cosmopolitan fluency and local solidarity at the same time.

Cebuano-background speakers draw on a third set. Alongside English markers (*so*, *basically*, *but then*), they use expressions such as *bahala na* ‘come what may’ and *basta* ‘as long as’ (8), and Cebuano clitics such as *man gani*, *sad*, and *gyud* for emphasis (9). The affective-emphatic cluster *man gani* (Tanangkingsing, 2009) is placed after the English clause, whereas its English counterpart *even* would precede the verb; inserting it before the verb is dispreferred.

(8) *Bahala na* if you got COVID, *basta* you feed your family.
‘It doesn’t matter if you got COVID, as long as you feed your family.’

(9) I sent them pictures, *man gani*. ‘I even sent them pictures.’

4.2 Lexical innovations

To describe the social vocabulary of Conyo English in terms that later studies can reuse, we follow Bautista’s (1997) classification of the Philippine English lexicon by word-formation process: normal expansion, preservation, coinage, and borrowing. The first three yield words of English form; borrowing brings in words of non-English form. Classifying conyo vocabulary in this way also shows how it relates to the lexicon of PhE at large.

Normal expansion, the use of English words with extended or altered meanings, is seen most clearly in kinship terms. As in PhE generally, *auntie* is extended to older women outside the family as a term of warmth and respect. Several other expansions come from global youth English rather than from PhE: *baddie* and *slaying* as terms of approval, and *shipping* for playfully pairing friends, from fandom culture. None of the items discussed here is a preservation, Bautista’s category for words that are archaic or rare in other varieties, which fits the variety’s orientation toward current campus and online usage.

Coinage accounts for much of the campus vocabulary, and much of it is institutional. Clippings such as *acads* ‘academics’, *org* ‘organization’, and *orals* ‘oral examinations’ (10) sit alongside initialisms such as *GC* ‘group chat’, *UP*, and the names of admission tests, the Ateneo College Entrance Test (*ACET*) and the National Medical Admission Test (*NMAT*) for medical school applicants. Compounds such as *blockmates* ‘classmates in the same block section’ (11) and *happy crush* ‘a harmless infatuation’ belong to the same campus world, and derivations from school names, *Povedan* and *ICAn*, identify graduates of elite private schools. Like campus names used without elaboration (*Ateneo*, *La Salle*, the *New Rizal* library), these coinages presuppose shared knowledge and so work as shibboleths of participation. Hybrid coinages combine both languages: *sana all* ‘wish everyone had that’, a mock expression of envy, joins Tagalog *sana* ‘hopefully’ to English *all* (12).

(10) Sorry, I can’t go—swamped with acads.

(11) He knows all of my blockmates that I’m close to.

(12) Dude, *sana all*!

Table 3: The ten most frequent verb lemmas in the data

Verb	Tokens	Representative example
know	750	I don't know.
go	646	Now, let's go to round zero.
say	385	Like, *diba* super… What do we say in the language?
think	294	I think that was true… I think everything should…
get	291	We got Thailand, Laos, and Vietnam to…
want	216	Or if you want to be one.
see	208	If they saw you with a good outfit, they'll be…
wait	163	Then wait here for the resources.
feel	129	I feel like Singapore.
talk	128	Or just you guys will talk?

Borrowing brings Tagalog words into English clauses untranslated, often with a shift in meaning or force. *Gago* 'fool' is softened by peer intimacy; *kalat* 'messy' is extended to social chaos and leaked gossip (13); and *budol* 'playful deceit', *sipsip* 'sycophant', and *bola* 'flattery' supply a repertoire of judgment and humor. Kinship terms such as *lolo* 'grandfather' and *tita* 'aunt' are borrowed with the same extension as *auntie*, and *tita* has further come to name a lifestyle persona, the nurturing or fashionable older woman.

(13) We'd be *kalat* in the GC.

Across the four processes, borrowing and normal expansion tie the vocabulary to Tagalog-speaking social life and to global youth culture, while coinage, especially clipping and initialisms, ties it to the campus and to online communication. Each item is a compact cultural reference, which is why the lexicon is both aspirational and easily parodied.

5 Grammar

This section follows the categories Borlongan (2011) used to describe the grammar of the PhE verb, namely tense and aspect, modality, and verb complementation, and then turns to the noun phrase and to clauses and sentences. Across all five, Conyo English redistributes grammatical work between English and Tagalog in a consistent way.

5.1 Tense and aspect

The data contain 683 distinct verb lemmas. The most frequent (Table 3) are cognitive and communicative verbs (*know*, *think*, *say*, *feel*), which mainly organize discourse and mark stance, and motion and directive verbs (*go*, *wait*), which are used in group planning.

Verbs appear overwhelmingly in their bare form regardless of time reference. Past-tense morphology occurs (*saw*, *got*), but irregularly, and temporal reference is carried instead by adverbs (*then*, *now*, *already*) and by the particles *na* and *pa*, much as in Tagalog, where tense is not obligatorily marked. Aspect, by contrast, is actively expressed. Completive aspect is marked by *na*, sometimes doubled by English *already* (14, 15), and continuation by *pa*; in short imperatives the particles alone supply the aspect, without tense inflection or auxiliaries (16, 17). Progressive meaning is expressed either by English *be* + *-ing* in semi-formal planning talk (18) or by Tagalog imperfective morphology on an English stem (*nagpapa-cute* 'acting cute'). The choice between the English and Tagalog strategies tracks the formality of the setting. Contractions are also frequent: *let's* is the default collective imperative, and *don't* serves as a general negator that combines freely with Tagalog particles (*You don't go na*).

(14) That one we already saw *na*.

(15) He finished *na* already.

(16) Let's go *na*!

(17) Wait *pa*!

(18) We are looking at that later.

Aspect is also marked morphologically, by Tagalog affixes attached directly to English stems (19–23):

(19) *Ino-know mo ba?* 'Are you going to find out (about it)?'

(20) *Fineel ko yung* vibes *mo*. 'I was feeling your vibe.'

(21) *Na-touch ako dun sa* speech. 'I was touched by the speech.'

(22) *I-re-read ko pa* later. 'I'll read it later.'

(23) *Mag-go na tayo!* 'Let's go now!'

The affixes follow familiar Tagalog patterns: the prefix *i-* with reduplication of the stem's first syllable for contemplative aspect (*ino-know* = *i-* + *no-* + *know*; *i-re-read*), *-in-* infixation for completed action (*fineel*), *na-* for resultative or inchoative meaning (*na-touch*, *na-cancel*), and *mag-* for volitional or hortative meaning (*mag-go*). These forms behave as lexicalized units: speakers retrieve them whole, and their meanings extend beyond the composition of their parts (*na-touch* 'emotionally moved'; *nagpapa-cute* 'acting cute'). They also serve as templates for new stems (*na-block*, *mag-drive*), and their regular appearance in typed chat messages shows deliberate adoption rather than incidental mixing. Where Yaya English *nag-cook* filled a lexical need, the conyo affix also signals identity: the hybridization itself marks the speaker as conyo.

Where events must be ordered, Conyo English relies on adverbial connectives rather than tense morphology. In (24), *then* sequences procedural steps much as Tagalog *tapos* does; in (25), *so* introduces a purpose or result; and in (26), *now* anchors a directive in the present, comparable to Tagalog *ngayon na* 'right now'. These connectives form an adverbial network that keeps temporal relations clear without inflection.

(24) Maybe it can be 6–4 for economics, then 4 for accounting.

(25) So China can visit five countries at a time.

(26) Now, let's go to round zero.

5.2 Modality

The English modal system is sharply reduced. *Can* remains common (about 130 tokens), but *must*, *should*, *could*, and *may* are rare. Deontic meaning is carried mainly by *want* (216), *can*, and *let's* (98), which present obligations as options, possibilities, and joint decisions (27, 28). This flattening of the modal hierarchy favors cooperation over authority, in keeping with the politeness norms of peer talk: *want* softens proposals into offers, *can* marks negotiation rather than ability, and *let's* frames decisions as shared.

(27) Or if you want to be one.

(28) Maybe it can be 6–4 for economics, then 4 for accounting. (cf. 24)

Epistemic stance is expressed through first-person stance verbs rather than modals: *I think* hedges claims, *I feel like* frames affective evaluations (*I feel like Singapore*), and *I don't know*, a recurring formula, acts as a polite shield against commitment. Tagalog particles add modal nuances that are independent of tense and polarity. *Na* turns *don't go* into a gentle plea (*Don't go na*), *diba* seeks confirmation (*Diba you can do that?*), and *lang* 'just' minimizes a claim to humorous effect (29). Tagalog and English tags can also be stacked (30). The overall effect is that modality in Conyo English serves interpersonal alignment more than the expression of logical necessity or possibility.

(29) Girl, girl math *lang*!

(30) *Tama ako*, right? 'I'm right, right?'

5.3 Verb complementation

Verb complementation is fluid and largely unmarked: *go* is intransitive in *Let's go na* but takes a path object in *We go that way next time*. Passives are rare; topic-fronting does their work, as in (14), where fronted *that one* and completive *na* give a perfective-passive reading without passive morphology. Tagalog clitics also mark arguments: in *Know mo ba siya?* 'Do you know him/her?', the genitive *mo* marks the actor.

The most distinctive complementation pattern is the light-verb construction. A small set of high-frequency English verbs (*make*, *go*, *get*, *wait*, *talk*, *do*) functions as a frame that accepts Tagalog roots or loosely specified complements. In (31) and (32), *make* takes a bare Tagalog root, *sabi* 'say' or *salita* 'speak', as its complement, forming a periphrastic predicate.

(31) How do we make *sabi*?

(32) He made *salita* to the guard *na*.

Similar combinations occur in Yaya English (*make laba* 'do the laundry', *go market*; Bautista, 1982), where they reflect second-language accommodation. In Conyo English, by contrast, they are deliberate and stylistic, used by fluent bilinguals as markers of a shared way of talking. The resulting verb phrase is layered: the English verb supplies the syntactic frame and the propositional content, while Tagalog roots, clitics, and particles supply lexical content, argument marking, aspect, and illocutionary force.

Cebuano-background speakers allow Cebuano syntax a larger role. In (33), the English clause lacks the object that English requires (*didn't do it*), and in (34) the English subject phrase depends on a Cebuano predicate, *naguba gyud* 'really destroyed'. Only context shows that the homes, not the people, were destroyed. Their Conyo English thus conforms to what Cebuano permits more than to English grammatical norms.

(33) *Murag*, we didn't *sad*. 'I think we didn't do it either.'

(34) A lot of people with glass homes *naguba gyud*. 'Many people's glass homes were completely destroyed.'

5.4 The noun phrase

The data contain 1,668 distinct noun lemmas, but the ten most frequent account for over a third of all noun tokens: *no* (211), *guy* (131), *time* (125), *people* (120), *thing* (110), *one* (98), *friend* (98), *girl* (80), *lot* (76), and *way* (69). They serve three functions. Relational nouns mark social proximity (*you guys*; the vocative in *Girl, girl math lang!*). Light nouns act as placeholders and response tokens: *thing* and *one* defer specificity, and *no* is mostly an interactional response, often doubled with Tagalog *hindi* for emphasis (*No, hindi kaya* 'No, that's not possible'). Evaluative nouns express stance rather than quantity (*Oh my gosh, that's a lot*; *think of it this way*). Even *time* and *people* are used less to measure or count than to evoke shared schedules and collective identity (*To the other people... we have to know our own*). In short, reference is backgrounded and participation foregrounded: conyo nouns are tools for organizing interaction and positioning speakers as much as for naming things.

Noun phrases also blend the two languages. English heads appear in Tagalog frames (35, 36); in (36), Tagalog plural *mga* combines with an already plural English noun. English compounds also combine with Tagalog vocatives (37). In each case Tagalog provides the grammatical frame and English the lexical content.

(35) *Ang* friend *mo* is there.

(36) *Mga* people *dito* are noisy.

(37) Birthday girl sis, *ikaw ang* guest of honor.

5.5 Clauses and sentences

Conyo English prefers coordination to subordination. The most frequent linkers are *and* (928 tokens), *like* (721), *but* (495), *because* (434), and *if* (265). *And* chains propositions and stances into long, speech-like stretches, and alternates with Tagalog *tapos* (38). *Like* is the most versatile item: it opens turns, introduces reported thought, marks comparison (*I feel like Singapore*), and fills pauses alongside *parang* (*Parang like why bother?*).

(38) We do this, and then we present, *tapos* we submit.

The subordinators are used conversationally. *Because* usually adds a justification after a claim has been made (*I think that's difficult because there's a change…*), mirroring Tagalog *mahirap siya kasi…* 'it's hard because…'. *If* typically frames an option rather than a hypothetical condition (*Or if you want to be one*; compare Tagalog *kung gusto mo* 'if you want'). *But* marks a stance shift after the speaker has first agreed: agreement comes first and the qualification follows, a strategy of face management.

Linking can also be marked twice, once in each language (39, 40). This doubling, like *No, hindi kaya*, serves to intensify; it is not accidental redundancy. In planning talk, clauses are strung together at a single level by sequential adverbs, with aspect marked by a final *na* (41). The flat, additive clause structure and the minimal tense marking of Section 5.1 go together. Both shift the work of structuring discourse from syntax to particles, adverbs, and prosody.

(39) It's hard *kasi* because you have to change groups.

(40) *Kung* if *'yun ang gusto mo…* 'If that's what you want…'

(41) We do this first, then you present, then we send, then finish *na*.

6 Synthesis and discussion

The preceding sections show that Conyo English is not random code-mixing but a patterned way of distributing work between English and Tagalog, with recognizable social meanings. This section draws the findings together. It considers what the variety does socially and how its speakers regard it, how variation within it can be modeled as a gradient, what distinguishes it from Taglish, how it has changed since Perez (1993), how it can be understood as an enregistered sociolect, and what it suggests about the development of Philippine English, and it closes with the limits of the present findings.

Reyes (2017a, 2020) describes the conyo speaker as a social type associated with mestizaje, private education, and cosmopolitanism, situated within what Martin (2014) calls the Philippine Inner Circle, the speakers of highly Americanized or prestigious English. Our informants recognized this association and the charge of being *pa-sosyal* 'pretentious, putting on airs', but most explained their own usage biographically, pointing to English-dominant homes, international or private schooling, or peer groups in which English was the default. As one informant put it, "It becomes Conyo because of my cultural background—learning English more than Filipino, so my Filipino sounds weird." Such accounts support McKenzie's (2013) point that language attitudes stand in for broader evaluations of prestige and in-group identity, and they position Conyo English as a form of symbolic capital (Bourdieu, 1991): valued, scrutinized, or mocked depending on the setting.

Consistent with Borlongan's (2015) domain analysis, Conyo English appeared mostly in casual peer interaction, such as group work, hallway banter, meals, and organization meetings. Within these settings, speakers moved between English, Taglish, and Tagalog according to topic, tone, and audience, and these shifts were interactionally meaningful. In the following classroom exchange, switching frames a disagreement and softens a correction:

A: I would say like management of logistical issues. What do you say?
B: *Parang* logistical issues regarding the transportation… *kasi*, you know, you communicate it properly, *pero* there's a misunderstanding like *yung* jeep.
A: Right, *wala ngang* jeep. So handling logistics is a problem.

B's *parang* and *kasi* hedge a partial disagreement, and A's *right, wala ngang jeep* 'right, there really isn't a jeep' ratifies it before A reformulates the point. The bilingual repertoire offers face-saving resources that neither language provides as economically on its own.

In the post-recording interviews, some informants described Conyo English as a practical tool, others as an aesthetic choice, and a few as a source of anxiety about seeming pretentious or inauthentic; the label *conyo* itself carried both humorous and stigmatizing connotations. Media caricature presents the conyo speaker as Westernized, disengaged, and excessive, but in our data many students used Conyo English as a bridge language, as a default in particular settings, or as a marker of inclusion rather than exclusion.

Nor is Conyo English tied to a single class. Its use reflects schooling, urban exposure, peer norms, and personal history, and some students who grew up speaking Cebuano or Hiligaynon reported adopting it at university to "fit in." It therefore works both as a marker of privilege and as a means of linguistic adaptation. Regional background, moreover, is not erased. Perez (1993) and Gonzalez (1985) expected urban, educated youth speech to neutralize substrate features, yet our Cebuano-background speakers retained distinctive vowels, rising boundary tones, Cebuano particles, and Cebuano syntax (Sections 3–5). This is consistent with evidence that Tagalog and Cebuano speakers' English differs (Bolivar, 2020; Samejon, 2025), and in a mixed code such as Conyo English, substrate influence is, if anything, more likely to surface. The Davao variety, in which mixing occurs as much between Tagalog and Cebuano as with English (Albino et al., 2016), deserves separate study. Together, these regional variants support Gonzales's (2017) observation that Philippine Englishes are diversifying both socially and regionally.

Acceptance of Conyo English outside the peer group remains mixed. As with PhE generally (Bautista, 2001; Borlongan, 2009), recognition does not guarantee approval, and judgments of prestige are shaped by ideologies of "correct" or "global" English (Bernardo, 2011; Garrett, 2010) and by the tension between English as colonial legacy and as contemporary resource (Tupas, 2004, 2011; Martin, 2014). One informant's remark that "Conyo is just a nicer way of saying you don't speak proper Filipino" captures this ambivalence. Yet students rarely rejected their own hybrid speech outright. They acknowledged its expressive value while criticizing its social implications, a reflexive stance to which we return below.

The features described in Sections 3 to 5 are not present in every conyo utterance; they vary in density from speaker to speaker and from moment to moment. We call this variation *conyoness* and model it as a gradient rather than as a set of levels. Three dimensions can be distinguished, each of which can in principle be measured: *particle density*, the number of Tagalog and English discourse particles per clause; *hybridization depth*, the extent to which English stems carry Tagalog morphology, from uninflected English verbs to affixed forms such as *ino-know*; and *social indexical load*, the proportion of institutional, digital, or affective vocabulary (*Ateneo*, *GC*, *kalat*, *tita*).

The three dimensions vary independently, which is why they cannot be collapsed into a single scale. An utterance can be dense with particles yet show no hybrid morphology (*Like, parang okay lang naman, diba?*); it can be morphologically hybrid yet low in indexical load (*Mag-go na tayo*); and it can carry a heavy indexical load with few particles (*Sorry, may acads pa and our GC is kalat na*). The most marked conyo talk combines high values on all three (42).

(42) *Tapos* I was like, *diba*, New Rizal is so noisy *na*, so I just *i-GDrive ko na lang—kalat na kasi sa* GC.

Conyoness is thus the density and combination of conyo resources, not simply the amount of Tagalog used. Speakers move along each dimension according to audience, setting, and intention: low values resemble a general Manila youth English with Tagalog pragmatic punctuation, while high values on all three produce the most marked, stylized conyo talk. The model also explains why outsiders perceive Conyo English as a single thing while insiders hear many gradations: caricatures draw almost entirely on talk that is high on all three dimensions, whereas most everyday conyo talk in our data combines them far more sparingly.

A persistent problem in the literature is distinguishing Conyo English from Taglish, the broader practice of English–Tagalog code-switching found across Philippine society. Our data suggest four properties that, in combination, define the variety. First, English supplies the clause frame, and Tagalog (or, for Cebuano-background speakers, Cebuano) contributes mainly pragmatic and aspectual

material, through particles at clause edges and in the verb phrase, rather than alternating with English clause by clause. Second, Tagalog morphology and light-verb frames are applied to English stems (*na-touch*, *mag-go*, *make sabi*), producing a semi-productive set of hybrid verbs. Third, Conyo English has a characteristic prosody: syllable timing, Tagalog-like falling and plateau contours, pockets of AmE stylization, and the conyo contour. Fourth, it draws on a socially indexed vocabulary of elite campus life and digital culture.

None of these properties is unique to Conyo English. Particles occur throughout Taglish, and hybrid verbs occur in Yaya English. What identifies the variety is their co-occurrence and density, which is exactly what the gradient of conyoness is designed to capture. On this view, Taglish is the broader field of English–Tagalog mixing, and Conyo English is a socially marked region within it, characterized by an English-dominant frame, deep but selective hybridization, and a high indexical load. This definition is narrower than popular usage, in which *conyo* can label almost any English-heavy speech by the affluent, but it can be tested against data in a way that the popular label cannot.

Perez (1993) documented frequent alternation, carried largely by interjections, enclitics, and pragmatic particles, among students at a private women's college, and treated it as an informal mode rather than a distinct variety. Three decades on, much of what she observed persists: particles and enclitics remain the backbone of the variety, and Tagalog intonation still underlies English utterances. What has changed is the degree of integration. Conyo English now includes stable morphological innovations (*na-touch*, *ino-know*, *make sabi*) and a systematic pairing of Tagalog and English discourse markers, which point to grammatical integration rather than casual alternation. It is also no longer confined to a single gendered and institutional setting: our speakers came from four universities, and men outnumbered women. Where Perez described a binary alternation between two languages, the present data are better described as a gradient along which speakers calibrate their choices to audience, topic, and identity. What she captured in its early form as a playful in-group code has become a structured register with its own lexical, grammatical, and pragmatic norms.

Conyo speakers are highly aware of their own speech. They parody it ("*Wait lang*, I'm so conyo right now"), repeat discourse markers ironically, and exaggerate Tagalog particles for comic effect. Such reflexivity is the hallmark of enregisterment, the process by which a set of linguistic features comes to be recognized as a register linked to a social type (Agha, 2007). The concept of indexical order (Silverstein, 2003) helps to separate the layers involved. At the first order, particles, hybrid verbs, and campus vocabulary simply index casual, intimate peer talk among bilingual students. At the second order, speakers and outsiders link the same features to a recognizable persona, the affluent, private-schooled *conyo*. At the third order, speakers take up that persona ironically, invoking it to joke, to distance themselves from it, or to claim it.

These layers explain why the same features can be prized and mocked at once. Rather than carrying a single fixed meaning, they occupy an indexical field (Eckert, 2008) whose potential meanings range from privilege and cosmopolitanism to intimacy, humor, and inclusion, and context selects among them. A *naman* that softens a request among friends and the same *naman* exaggerated in a parody video draw on one field but activate different points in it. The ability to move along the dimensions of conyoness is therefore a form of linguistic capital: speakers who can modulate their conyoness display both cultural agility and insider status. What looks like interference from outside is, from inside, controlled stylistic choice.

A comparison with Yaya English sharpens the point. The same structural resources, *make* + Tagalog root and Tagalog affixes on English stems, appear in both sociolects, which sit at opposite ends of the Philippine social hierarchy. In Yaya English they reflect accommodation by speakers with limited access to English (Bautista, 1982); in Conyo English they are chosen by fluent bilinguals for stylistic effect. What separates the two sociolects, then, is less their structure than the indexical meaning of the shared structures and the social position of their speakers. Sociolectal description in Philippine English therefore needs to attend to what features mean to their users, not only to which features occur.

Borlongan (2016) argues that PhE has reached endonormative stabilization, and Gonzales (2017) suggests that it may already be moving into differentiation, the fifth phase of Schneider's (2007) model, in which a stabilized national variety gives rise to social and regional subvarieties. Conyo English supports the second view. Its features are not random instances of switching but stable, rule-governed patterns shared within communities of practice, used largely without negative evaluation inside those communities and recognized as a named variety outside them. The Cebuano-inflected

variants show that the same differentiation is occurring regionally. A single sociolect cannot establish the phase of an entire national variety, but it is the kind of evidence Phase 5 predicts. The national norm is stable enough that new subvarieties, each tied to particular groups, institutions, and settings, can form within it.

Several limits qualify these findings. The study reported in this article relied on a convenience sample weighted toward one university, and the Cebuano observations rest on only two speakers who happened to be part of the Metro Manila sample; a dedicated sample of Cebuano-background speakers is needed. Our informants were also all university students, yet Conyo English is not confined to the young: some speakers of older generations use it too, and its use across age groups deserves study. The phonological analysis is largely auditory; the conyo contour in particular needs controlled acoustic study across more speakers and a comparison group of non-conyo Tagalog–English bilinguals. Frequencies are raw counts from a modest body of recordings and have not been compared with a baseline of general Taglish or PhE conversation, so claims about what is distinctive to Conyo English remain provisional. The three dimensions of conyoness have yet to be measured systematically; doing so, for example by counting particles, hybrid forms, and indexical items per clause, would allow the model to be tested across speakers and settings. Future work should also examine Davao conyo, Conyo English in digital writing, and change over time within the same peer networks.

7 Conclusion

This article offers the most comprehensive description of Conyo English to date, and the first since Perez (1993) to be based on spontaneous peer-group conversation. Phonologically, Conyo English keeps the core segmental features of PhE, including [d] for /ð/, unaspirated plosives, and full vowels in unstressed syllables, together with selected AmE features such as the alveolar tap. Its rhythm is syllable-timed, its stress tends toward the penult, and its intonation is predominantly Tagalog-like: falling or level at phrase boundaries, with rises reserved for tags, clitics, and emphasis. It also has a distinctive intonation pattern of its own, the conyo contour. Lexically, it pairs Tagalog particles with English discourse markers and builds its social vocabulary through normal expansion, coinage, and borrowing, much of it tied to campus and digital life. Grammatically, it attaches Tagalog aspect morphology to English stems, leaves tense largely unmarked, expresses aspect and modality through particles, takes bare Tagalog roots as verb complements, and links clauses additively.

This article makes three contributions. Empirically, it provides the first consented, multi-university collection of naturally occurring Conyo English, transcribed in full. Descriptively, it gives the first account of the variety's phonology, including the conyo contour, alongside its lexicon and grammar, and it documents Cebuano-inflected variants. Theoretically, it offers a working definition that separates Conyo English from Taglish, a gradient model of conyoness that makes variation within the variety describable, and an account of Conyo English as an enregistered sociolect whose features carry layered and context-dependent meanings. As the Philippines is a migrant nation, this article also offers further insights on how language varieties evolve in migratory contexts (cf. Borlongan & Vilog, 2024), and thus makes a contribution to the emerging discipline of migration linguistics (Borlongan, 2019, 2023a; also Borlongan & Kurusu, 2026; Ponce & Borlongan, 2026).

We have argued that these features co-occur in a way that distinguishes Conyo English from Taglish generally, that the gradient of conyoness captures how speakers vary their use of them, and that Conyo English is an enregistered sociolect whose meanings speakers manipulate with considerable awareness. Speakers from Cebuano backgrounds show that the variety is also regionally inflected. Conyo English continues the line of Philippine sociolects described since Yaya English (Bautista, 1982), now in a digital, globalized setting, and its emergence is consistent with PhE's movement into differentiation. For World Englishes research, the case shows that the endpoint of nativization is not a single, uniform local standard but a set of socially meaningful varieties within it, and that some of the clearest evidence of a variety's maturity comes from the playful, stigmatized, and self-conscious styles that standard descriptions tend to set aside. In the speech of these students, English functions less as a language of power than as one of belonging.

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Statements and Declarations

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Data Availability Statement. The audio recordings and full transcripts are not publicly available because they contain informants' voices and potentially identifying personal information, which informants were assured would be protected. Anonymized excerpts are available from the corresponding author on reasonable request.

Declaration of Authors' Contributions. Ariane Macalinga Borlongan: conceptualization; writing of the introduction and the synthesis and discussion. Jasper Kyle Catapang: analysis and writing of the lexicon and grammar sections; writing of the synthesis and discussion and the conclusion. Kevin Samejon: phonological transcription and analysis. Sae Asamura: informant recruitment and data collection; transcription and annotation; data pre-processing; writing of the introduction and the aims and methods. All authors reviewed and approved the final manuscript.

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Declaration of AI Use. OpenAI's Whisper was used to produce first-pass automatic transcriptions of the recordings, all of which were manually corrected by the researchers (Section 2.2). Anthropic's Claude was used to polish the manuscript to conform to the journal's guidelines and to proofread and copyedit the text. All AI-assisted output was reviewed by the authors, who take full responsibility for the content of this article.

Author Bionotes

Ariane Macalinga Borlongan is a public intellectual, language scholar, and migrant advocate. His body of work encompasses contributions to atlases, dictionaries, encyclopedias, newspapers, and, notably, Bibles. He is the youngest to earn a doctorate in linguistics, at age 23 from De La Salle University, and has had several teaching and research positions in Germany, Japan, Malaysia, the Philippines, Poland, and Singapore. He is presently Associate Professor of Sociolinguistics and Founder and Head of The Migration Linguistics Initiative at the Tokyo University of Foreign Studies.

Jasper Kyle Catapang is an AI safety researcher in industry and a doctoral candidate at the Graduate School of Global Studies, Tokyo University of Foreign Studies, where he studies how language technologies reshape language, culture, and power. Drawing on seven years in natural language processing, his dissertation develops a computational theory of lexical stabilization in World Englishes. He holds a master's in applied linguistics from the University of Birmingham.

Kevin Samejon is an Assistant Professor of English at the University of Nebraska at Omaha, where he also directs the Sociolinguistics & Language Structures (SoLaS) Lab. His research focuses on sociolinguistic variation, bilingualism, phonetics and phonology, and Philippine languages.

Sae Asamura is an alumna of the English major in the School of Language and Culture Studies, Tokyo University of Foreign Studies. She collected the data for the study reported in this article while an international exchange student in International Relations at Ateneo de Manila University. Her research interests are sociolinguistics, World Englishes, and Philippine Englishes.

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